

Negatives and their scope

Teaching guide

Make clear what is not true or not required.

Understand the distinction

In standard written English, combine not with any or use no: I do not have any cash / I have no cash. Other dialects use negative concord, such as not ... nothing; recognize it without treating its speakers as less capable.

Position changes scope. Not everyone came means some people did not come; nobody came means zero people came. Must not means prohibited, while do not have to means optional. Check what part of the meaning you are negating.

Compare the patterns

PART OF A GROUP

Not everyone agreed.

At least one person did not agree.

ZERO

Nobody agreed.

No person agreed.

OPTIONAL

You do not have to attend.

Attendance is not required.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the standard formal-English version: I do not have no time.

A. I do not have any time.

B. I have any time.

C. I do not have some no time.

2. Does Not all seats are taken mean every seat is empty?

A. No. It means every seat is occupied.

B. No. It means at least some seats are free.

C. Yes. It means no seats are occupied.

3. Which means prohibited: must not / do not have to?

A. Both mean the action is forbidden.

B. do not have to

C. must not

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Printing the form is optional; sharing a password is forbidden. Which wording matches?

A. You must not print the form. You do not have to share your password.

B. You have to print the form. You must not share your password.

C. You do not have to print the form. You must not share your password.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. I do not have any time.

Alternatively: I have no time.

B: Without the negative, this does not express the intended lack of time.

C: For this standard negative, use do not have any time.

2. B. No. It means at least some seats are free.

Not all and none have different meanings.

A: That would mean all seats are taken, the opposite of not all.

C: Not all denies that every seat is taken; some can still be occupied.

3. C. must not

Do not have to removes an obligation.

A: Must not forbids; do not have to makes the action optional.

B: This means not required, not prohibited.

4. C. You do not have to print the form. You must not share your password.

Do not have to removes necessity; must not prohibits an action.

A: This forbids printing and makes sharing optional, changing both rules.

B: Have to makes printing required, contrary to the stated rule.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-25.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Printing the form is optional; sharing a password is forbidden. Which wording matches?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.